

BLEED AI · GROWTH PLAYBOOK

The LinkedIn Growth Masterclass

From zero to expert — a lesson-by-lesson curriculum built from deep research on Lara Acosta, Pierre Herubel, Adam Robinson, Justin Welsh, Jasmin Alić, Ruben Hassid, Matt Gray, the 2025/26 algorithm science (360Brew, van der Blom, AuthoredUp), and a 6,642-post corpus.

Living document — regenerated from `playbook/LINKEDIN-GROWTH-MASTERCLASS.md`; the same Drive link updates in place.

The LinkedIn Growth Masterclass — from zero to expert

A lesson-by-lesson curriculum. Read it top to bottom once and you understand LinkedIn growth the way the top 0.1% do. Built 2026-07-11 from deep research on **Lara Acosta, Pierre Herubel, Adam Robinson, Justin Welsh, Jasmin Alić, Ruben Hassid** (+ Coleman, Bourgoïn, Natividad, Matthews), the **2025/26 algorithm science** (van der Blom's 1.8M-post report, AuthoredUp's 3M-post format study, LinkedIn's own 360Brew papers), and our **own 6,642-post cold-email corpus**.

How this fits the other docs (no duplication):

- **PLAYBOOK.md** = the original 9-expert tactical reference (Matt Gray, Hormozi, MrBeast...). Still valid; this doc extends it with new creators + algorithm data.
- **WINNER-RATE-PLAYBOOK.md** = Taha-specific strategy + our corpus findings.
- **COPYWRITING-BIBLE.md** / **FORMAT-LIBRARY.md** / **POST-STRUCTURE-LIBRARY.md** = deep craft references.
- **STRATEGY.md** = the why/who. **This doc = the complete teaching curriculum that ties it all together.**

The 8 modules: 0) The 2026 reality · 1) Positioning · 2) The algorithm · 3) The craft · 4) Distribution · 5) Monetization · 6) Systems · 7) The synthesis (consensus vs. your bets) · 8) Taha's pro strategy.

MODULE 0 — The 2026 reality (why most advice is stale)

Lesson 0 — The ground truth you're operating in

Three facts change everything, and most "LinkedIn tips" ignore them:

1. **Reach collapsed year-over-year.** Van der Blom's 2025 report (1.8M posts): **views –50%, engagement –25%, follower growth –59%.** The bar to win went up. Volume-spray doesn't work anymore.

1. **Almost nobody actually posts.** Only ~7.1% of LinkedIn's ~1B members post regularly; ~570M read but never engage. **Consistency alone puts you in the top 7%.** This is the single most encouraging fact in the whole doc.

1. **The feed is now an LLM.** In 2025 LinkedIn replaced its old recommender with **360Brew — a ~150-billion-parameter language model* *that reads and understands your actual text and matches it against a semantic embedding of your profile. Consequences run through every lesson below: keyword-stuffing, hashtag games, and template hacks work less; genuine on-topic substance works more**.

What's now stale (delete from memory): "post at exactly 8am to win the golden hour" (the hour softened — posts now live ~2 weeks); "spam hashtags for reach"; "links always kill reach, no exceptions"; "carousels always win" (only past ~20K followers — see Lesson 7). **What's newly true:** saves and "sends" are now the top signals (LinkedIn added them to analytics in late 2025); AI-obvious text is penalized; your headline literally shapes what the algorithm thinks you're allowed to post about.

Mindset: growth = *positioning* × *craft* × *distribution* × *consistency*, operating inside an LLM that rewards on-topic substance. Every lesson is one of those four levers.

MODULE 1 — Positioning (win before you post)

Lesson 1 — Pick a lane you can own (the anti-commodity test)

The #1 mistake is posting *before* deciding what you're the person for. Two experts converge here:

- **Lara Acosta's SMPV.** Find the intersection of **S**kill (what you're most *useful* at),

Market (your industry/experience), **P**roblem (what people actually want — status, money, freedom), **V**alue (your differentiator = *lived experience*). Her rule: "*stay in the middle — too broad and you get diluted, too niche and no one sees you.*"

- **Pierre Herubel's anti-commodity test.** Before publishing, ask: *could a competitor publish this

exact post? *If yes, it's commoditized and worthless. Differentiation = **proprietary insight + signature POV + real proof from things you actually did.** His definition of expertise: "an in-demand skill that's easy for you but hard for others... what's left after you tried, failed, and adjusted in the real world."**

The unlock — "turn the how-to into a how-I" (Lara). Generic knowledge is a commodity; your *lived experience* of that knowledge is not. Don't write "5 cold-email tips" — write "the 5 things I changed after 4,000 emails got 1 reply."

Premium positioning — the Swiss-Army-knife problem (Lara Acosta's team). The #1 profile mistake is trying to be *everything to everyone* ("marketing expert · consultant · speaker · coach · marathon runner") — a Swiss Army knife that has every tool and does nothing. The top 0.1% do the opposite: **everything to ONE ideal person.** This is the difference between a **\$9 airport sandwich and a \$45 one** — you stop competing on price and compete on *outcome*. The move: swap a **job title for a reason to buy.**

- Weak: "*I'm a sales coach.*" → Premium: *"I help 7-figure founders close high-ticket clients*

*without a single cold call."**

- Weak: "*I help businesses grow.*" → Premium: *"I help B2B SaaS founders who've plateaued at \$1M ARR*

*break through to \$10M using a proven GTM framework."**

- **The formula:** **specific audience + specific outcome + undeniable proof**. Swap "businesses" →

"B2B SaaS founders", "grow" → "\$1M to \$10M ARR", "help" → "proven GTM framework."

- This isn't just conversion — LinkedIn's algorithm now ***rewards this specificity at the distribution*

*level*** (it's the same profile→post match from Lesson 3). Clarity is a reach setting.

Own one word (Matt Gray). Pick the single word you want to own in your customer's mind and put it in your one-liner: *stoicism* → *Ryan Holiday*, *productivity* → *Ali Abdaal*, *habits* → *James Clear*, *systems* → *Matt Gray*. When they think the word, they think of you.

Taha application: his lane is **"the operator who runs a real cold-email agency and is automating it with Claude Code."** Nobody can copy his actual client campaigns, his real numbers, or his live build. That's the moat. His word to own: **"cold email"** (or "outbound systems").

Lesson 2 — The content map: 3 pillars × 5 subtopics

Once you have the lane, **Pierre's model** turns it into an infinite content engine:

- Pick a **maximum of 3 content pillars** (core themes tied to your business + audience pain).

His warning: add an unrelated 4th pillar and "*within ~3 weeks it dilutes your positioning totally.*"

- **Break each pillar into ~5 subtopics** → a 3×5 grid = 15 evergreen veins you rotate forever.

This is the cure for the blank page.

- **Positioning is cumulative:** *"you build it over hundreds of posts that connect, not one viral hit."*
- **One lane — "you are not the niche, your niche is a niche" (Lara Acosta).** Going off-topic even

occasionally adds *noise* to the picture the algorithm is building of you, and distribution drops across **everything**, not just that post. Pick one core topic + adjacent subtopics that all tie back to it. The algorithm (and human memory) rewards specialists, not generalists. Clean, consistent signal = the system can confidently place you and go find your audience.

The founder-brand thesis on top (Adam Robinson): *"Building a personal brand on LinkedIn is the fastest, highest-leverage way to grow a startup that has ever existed."* Because when you sell to your own audience, **content = product marketing at zero incremental cost**. For Bleed AI, Taha's audience (B2B founders/agency owners) *is* the ICP. His content isn't "marketing for the company" — it is the distribution channel. Adam attributes **~99% of RB2B's signups to his founder brand**.

Taha's 3 pillars (recommended):

1. **Cold-email tactics with proof** (teardowns, client case-studies, the stat-nuggets).
 2. **Building the AI-powered agency in public** (Claude Code / Clay / n8n — the current viral wave).
 3. **Operator POV / contrarian takes on the outbound industry** (rationed — see Lesson 5 on why).
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MODULE 2 — The algorithm (how reach actually works in 2026)

Lesson 3 — How 360Brew decides who sees you

The profile→post embedding match (the most important new mechanic). 360Brew builds an embedding of your professional identity from your **headline, About section, and experience**, and embeds every post in the same space. Post *far* from your profile's meaning → it reads as "misalignment" and reach is throttled. **Practical law: post on-topic to your stated expertise. Your headline is a reach setting, not a vanity label** (more in Lesson 10).

The distribution funnel (3 stages):

1. **Spam/quality filter (0–60 min):** classified low- or high-quality.
2. **Test batch (~first 60–120 min):** shown to a small slice of your audience — *your notifications-on followers and habitual engagers first.* Their early reaction decides expansion.

1. **Relevance expansion:** strong early engagement → pushed to 2nd/3rd-degree connections and topic followers.

The golden hour — real but softened. First **60–90 minutes** of momentum is still the strongest single predictor of final reach, with re-activation windows at **~6–8h and ~24h**. BUT since 2025, LinkedIn resurfaces relevant posts **2–3 weeks** later, so a post has a ~2-week life and exact posting *time* matters less than it did. Win the first 90 minutes with engagement (Lesson 8), but don't obsess over the perfect clock.

Dwell time = the strongest observable lever. How long people actually read. Reported correlation: 0–3 sec dwell ≈ 1.2% engagement/limited reach; **61+ sec ≈ 15.6% engagement/max reach**. Everything in Module 3 (hook, structure, format, whitespace) exists to buy dwell time.

Lesson 4 — The signal hierarchy (and what kills reach)

What the algorithm values, highest to lowest:

- **Saves = the #1 signal** (it costs the user something → highest intent). ~5× the reach value of a like, ~2× a meaningful comment. LinkedIn *added Saves + Sends to analytics in late 2025* — it's telling you what it now optimizes for. → **Build save-worthy posts: frameworks, checklists, specific data.**
- **Comments >> likes.** Trust the **~2–4× likes** figure (van der Blom); ignore the "15× comments" blog hype. **Comment length matters: 15+ word comments ≈ 2× the impact** of short ones.
- **Sends (private shares) > public reshares.** A plain reshare is nearly dead: **0.29× reach**.
- **Likes** = weakest positive signal.

Recall our own scoring rule ties to this: `score = likes + comments×3`. The platform and our tracker agree — **comments are the currency**.

What KILLS reach (memorize this list):

Killer	Penalty	Rule
Outbound link in post body	contested (see Lesson 4b)	van der Blom's data shows –40–70%; Lara Acosta + LinkedIn's own product director say the penalty ended ~2 years ago and the <i>real</i> killers are a link with no story or a link that doesn't match the post. Safest play stays: strong native post, link in first comment.
AI-obvious text	–30% reach, –55% engagement	Sound human. Emoji-walls now read as AI.
Editing after ~30 min	–30% to –50% impressions	Fix typos within 10 min or wait until reach is spent. Edits <i>pause then lower</i> distribution.
Engagement pods	detectable, plateauing/negative	Don't. Reciprocal non-relevant engagement is flagged.
"Comment YES if..." bait	down-ranked	A <i>genuine</i> question is fine; a bait <i>command</i> is not.
6+ hashtags	"seriously sabotages reach"	2–4 relevant tags , never a wall.
3+ same-format posts in a row	–20%	Vary formats.
Posting > 1×/24h	2nd post cannibalizes the 1st	The 24-hour rule — space posts ≥24h apart.

Lesson 4b — LinkedIn's 360Brew paper, decoded (Lara Acosta's breakdown)

In 2025 LinkedIn published (then quietly withdrew) the research paper describing the new feed. Lara Acosta — who'd been teaching this from her own data for years — decoded it. This is the deepest, most current read on how the machine actually thinks, and it *corrects* several "expert" myths:

Your profile is a prompt. The system converts your *entire* profile — headline, experience, skills, certifications, every field — into text and feeds it into an AI prompt to decide who your content is for. A profile that says "*brand designer*" gets a completely different audience than "*I help D2C founders build brand identities that convert*" — **same person, same post, different distribution, purely from profile wording.** Vague profile = nothing to match = your content goes nowhere no matter how good it is. (This is the sharpest version of the Lesson 3 profile↔post match.)

Connected vs. unconnected content (confirmed by LinkedIn's Sr Dir of Product, Oct 2024). Your feed now has two streams: **connected** (people you follow) and **unconnected** (content LinkedIn surfaces by *interest* and *what your network engages with*, from people you've never met). A post reaches a stranger because *someone they follow* liked, commented, or reshared it — and it **doesn't need to be viral**, just useful/relevant enough for one person to engage. → **Your network isn't just your audience, it's your distribution system.** Shareability + comment-worthiness matter more than ever (this is *why* the commenting system in Lesson 8b is so powerful now).

The beginner's advantage is real now. The old system needed years of interaction data, so it was biased toward big accounts (more followers = more auto-reach). The new one understands you from *text alone*, so **the performance gap favors small accounts most** — a great, specific post from a 500-follower account can genuinely outperform a mediocre one from a 100K account. There has never been a better time to start.

Relevancy over recency (the second wave). The old algo judged a post in the first day, then forgot it. The new one **re-assesses posts continuously and can give a great post a second wave weeks later** (like YouTube resurfacing an old video). **One genuinely useful post keeps generating leads for weeks** — so front-load quality, not just frequency.

The myths this paper kills (nuanced):

•  "Educational is the best viral format." No — education vs. storytelling shows ****no significant**

performance difference. **What matters is** content-founder-fit** (Lesson 7c below).

- ❌ "Text-only is the worst format." No — text-only is going viral constantly right now, especially

from beginners and domain experts with something real to say, clearly written.

- ❌ "External links kill reach." Not anymore (changed ~2 yrs ago; LinkedIn confirmed). Link posts

fail when they have **no story/insight** or the **link doesn't match the post** — not because of the link itself.

- ❌ "Video doesn't work on LinkedIn." It does, done right: a **3-second visual hook that compresses

the whole concept + ~500 words of post copy above the video** + genuine relevance to a pro audience.

The 3 Ps (the packaging test): Positioning (crystal clarity on what you do — makes people find and follow you) ·

Packaging (framing ideas simply enough that people want to read and use them) · **Proof** (screenshots, testimonials, measurable results — makes people believe and buy). It's the old "known, liked, trusted," updated.

The midwit curve (where to be): *beginners* who post authentically often do well; the *right side* understands it comes down to being good at one thing, staying consistent, and letting the algo find the audience; the **midwits in the middle** obsess over posting times and hacking every signal and get the *worst* results. **Don't be a midwit — move right.**

MODULE 3 — The craft (writing the post)

Lesson 5 — The hook: the entire game

Every top creator obsesses over the same ~2 lines because that's all the feed previews before "...see more" (~140 chars on mobile, ~210 on desktop — write for the mobile fold).

The science (tested data):

- **Curiosity-gap hooks** ≈ 6.8% engagement; **contrarian** ≈ 6.2% — the two top types. **Together they outperform everything else by ~2.3x.**
- **Personal-story hooks** ≈ 5.4% but generate the **MOST inbound DMs** — best when the goal is leads, not reach.
- **Data hooks** earn **saves** (durable, multi-week distribution).
- **Hooks under 10 words outperform longer ones by ~40%.**

What the experts add on top of the data:

- **Lara Acosta:** hook = **specific outcome + bold statement, ~8 words, mobile-first, emotional.**

Then her killer idea — **"every line is a hook."** *"All my best posts have more than one."* If a reader skims *any* line, that line must pull them in. She also insists on the **re-hook** (line 2 that re-earns the scroll right after the fold).

- **Jasmin Alić:** **hook + rehook** ("the hook gets you in the room; the rehook slams the door behind you"). His data: **one-line hooks always; hooks longer than a line perform ~20% worse; negative-word hooks ~30% worse.** Lead with your power statement — never bury it.

- **Ruben Hassid:** the **55-character rule** (~2 sentences of ~55 chars = everything above the fold)

and 5 named hook types: **Contradiction** ("The worst LinkedIn posts get the most followers"), **Specific-number** ("I unfollowed 2,000 people. My engagement tripled"), **Direct accusation** ("You're writing posts for your mom, not your audience"), **Stolen thought** (say what they secretly think), **Absurd reframe.** Unifying rule: a hook is a **pattern interrupt that opens a loop.**

Copy-paste hook templates:

- Curiosity: *"I [surprising claim]. Here's what nobody tells you →"*
- Contrarian: *"[Common advice] is killing your results."*
- Number: *"We analyzed [N]. One number shocked us:"*
- Story: *"A client fired us last week. Best thing that happened."*
- Loss/mistake: *"I lost [\$\$] because of one assumption."*
- "I did X": *"I [did specific thing] for 30 days. Here's what happened."*

2026 nuance: because saves now drive week-long distribution, **curiosity wins the scroll but save-worthy substance wins the week.** Open with intrigue, deliver something keepable.

Lesson 6 — Post structure: hold them to the end

Dwell time is the lever, so structure = buying reading time. Two proven skeletons:

- **Lara's SLAY:** Story (3–5 lines, a moment of tension) → Lesson (one sentence, jargon-free)

→ **Actionable advice** (3–5 numbered one-line steps you can do *today*) → **You** (a question that invites a *one-sentence comment*). ~200 words. *"Content is 20% writing, 80% psychology."*

- **Justin Welsh's Trailer / Meat / CTC:** write the **Meat first** (decide "2 learnings + 1 piece of

advice"). The **Trailer** is everything above "...more" — line 1 short/number-led, the last line before the fold is where they commit. End with a **summary + call-to-conversation** so they don't scroll back up before commenting.

The formatting rules (data-backed):

- **Length ~900–1,800 characters, substance-gated.** (AuthoredUp: 1,300–2,500 chars = peak engagement, ~+27% vs short posts; van der Blom: 900–1,500 for text+image. Reconcile: go long *only if every line earns it.*) The corpus agrees — Michel Lieben's best posts *hit the character limit*.
- **One idea per post.** "One post is one idea, one topic" (Pierre).
- **One sentence = one line.** Generous whitespace ≈ **+25%** performance. But **don't over-format** — bold-every-line / emoji-per-sentence now reads as AI.
- **4th-grade reading level.** Above ~10th grade = 35%+ less reach. Make the *reader* feel smart.
- **Single, well-placed emoji ok; walls of them hurt** (emoji use is falling as an AI tell).

Lesson 7 — Formats: the money table

AuthoredUp, 3M+ posts (Mar 2025–Feb 2026), reach multiplier vs. average:

Format	Reach	Engagement	Note
Poll	1.78×	0.37×	Reach-bait, conversation-poor. Use sparingly.
Document / carousel	1.39×	1.30×	Best all-rounder; 12.9% of all saves yet only ~4.9% of posts use it — biggest gap.
Image (single)	1.20×	1.33×	The safe default, especially small accounts.
Text-only	1.07×	0.78×	Fine, but a visual beats it.
Native video	0.86×	0.93×	Reach fell 36% YoY — weakest major format at scale.
Reshare	0.29×	0.22×	Nearly dead.

The two rules that matter most:

1. **Format performance flips by follower size.** Under ~5K followers, ****single images beat everything; carousels/documents only pull ahead past ~20K followers (1.30×) and 50K+* (1.49×).** So on a small account, don't chase carousels — post strong single-image posts.*
 1. **Visuals are a 3–10× reach multiplier** (Michel Lieben, confirmed across the corpus). ****A great visual on a text-only post can 5× reach.**** **Spend more time on the visual than the copy.** This is the single most under-used lever we control — and our visual pipeline (`VISUAL-TOOLKIT.md` , `content/`) is already built.
- On video:** if used, **first 8 seconds + subtitles are non-negotiable** (35% watch without sound); longer (3+ min) beats ultra-short. **On carousels:** Lara says they're past their prime for small accounts, the data says they win *only* at scale — both true. **Match format to your follower count. The video vanity trap (Jasmin Alić):** video is the psychologically *richest* format (voice, energy, face) so do it to *connect* — but don't chase it for reach. LinkedIn's video feed had a "gifted views" honeymoon where posts got millions of views with **zero** matching profile views, clicks, or business. **Views ≠ profile views ≠ leads.** Optimize for the metric that converts, not the ego number.

Lesson 7b — The viral content system (Matt Gray, 846K followers, 59M views/month)

Matt Gray grew to **846K followers in 36 months** (up to **102K/month**) and **59M organic views/month** with zero ads. His system is three parts: **profitable profile** (Lesson 10) · **engagement machine** (Lesson 8b) · **content system** (here).

The hook is your first 3 lines — if you don't stop the scroll there, you've lost them. His pattern:

1. **Line 1 = curiosity** — "I just read a study I can't stop thinking about."

2. **Line 2 = action + identity + data** — "Introverts are more effective leaders, according to

Harvard."* (calls out a specific group, cites data → instant reaction).

1. **Line 3 = immediate, contagious value** — a claim people *must* agree or disagree with, and that they'll share.

His 4 post types (rotate them):

- **Behind-the-scenes** — real stories from your journey (trials, wins, obstacles). Uses the words

I, I've, when, if. Proves there's a human, not AI, behind it.

- **Value-packed images** — see below.
- **Deep-work systems** — go deep on the *what* and the *how*; people follow for the details, so give them.
- **Personal stories** — "*your story is your competitive advantage*." Vulnerability is the superpower,

and it gets you out of LinkedIn's "cringe" zone.

Value-packed images are "algorithm juice." A dense, valuable image acts like a YouTube thumbnail for the post — one where Matt hand-wrote/visualized the whole post into an image pulled **24M views** (people literally printed it). Reinforces Lesson 7: **the visual is the reach lever**.

The 9 viral elements (condensed): personal stories · proven systems · value-bombing (maximize *value-per-second* — would a reader Slack this to their team?) · keep it **tasteful** (design/taste is a competitive edge on a cringey platform) · and the **5 power words in hooks: when · what · I · I've · how** (they force depth and a personal angle).

CTA science (stacked): ask for the **repost** (top reach signal), ask for the **follow**, and offer a **lead magnet tightly coupled to that post's topic** ("want my deep-work checklist?"). Coupling the magnet to the subject is what lifts click-through and lead volume.

Be a student of the game. Every **30 days**, review your **top 10% of posts** *and* scan other top creators' winners; double down on the patterns. Compounding math: **10% better each post = ~18,000× better by post 100**. Velocity of learning is the leading indicator of growth.

Lesson 7c — Content-founder-fit (Lara Acosta): pick the format that fits YOUR brain

The single biggest reason people copy a "winning format" and get worse results: **there is no universal best format — only the one that matches how you naturally think and communicate**. Two brain types:

- **Logical brain** — wired for frameworks, breakdowns, step-by-step. (Guy Macy, Chris Donnelly, Jake

Ward.) Their educational content hits *because it fits them*.

- **Creative brain** — wired for stories, experiences, hot takes. (Henry from Salt, Jasmin Alić, Lara.)

Their narrative content hits for the same reason.

Copying the *other* type's format underperforms — the platform (and the reader) can feel the mismatch. **Find your pocket and stay in it; results compound**. This is why the Lesson 7 "money table" is a *starting* guide, not gospel — aggregate averages, then override with what fits you and your audience. (Even Lara, mostly educational, finds her personal-story posts outperform everything — so test the blend.)

MODULE 4 — Distribution (getting seen)

Lesson 8 — The engagement engine (this is where growth actually happens)

The biggest strategic split among experts — and the highest-leverage lesson:

- **Jasmin Alić's stance (the strongest claim): "Post 7×/week max, but comment 20–30×/day."**

Commenting, not posting, was his growth engine. Leave 5–10 genuinely insightful comments daily on ~20–30 same-niche + ~10 adjacent creators; **hunt your ICP in other people's comment sections.**

- **Lara Acosta agrees:** comments were her *actual* growth engine more than posts — deep, valuable,

slightly sarcastic signature comments on big accounts to "steal audiences." **First hour: reply to every comment on your own post; then 2–3 hours engaging on others.**

- **Michel Lieben's 30/30 ritual:** 30 min engaging with other creators *before* posting, then reply

to every comment in the *first 30 min* after.

The data backs the ritual:

- Replying to your own comments ≈ **+30% engagement** (Buffer, ~72K posts; 83% of profiles saw lift).
- Reply to early commenters **within minutes during the golden hour** → ~doubles comment count exactly

when the test batch is being judged.

- **10 thoughtful comments/day for a month ≈ +40% profile visits.**
- **15+ word comments ≈ 2× impact.** Never leave "Great post!"
- End the post with a **genuine question ≈ +20–40% engagement.**

The choreography for every post: engage 30 min before → post → drop link/CTA in first comment → reply to every comment within minutes for the first hour → keep replying through the 6–8h window.

Your engagement habits decide who sees YOU (Lara, from the 360Brew paper). What you like and comment on doesn't just shape *your* feed — it tells the algorithm who you are and therefore who your posts get shown to. A freelance designer who spends months engaging with generic motivational content gets filed into *that* world and shown to *those* people, not startup founders. **Audit who you engage with; if they're not who you want in front of, shift your engagement to your ICP's world.** Every like is a signal.

Lesson 8b — The commenting SYSTEM (the deepest-leverage tactic, and the one nobody can throttle)

The algorithm can tank your reach 50% overnight; it cannot touch a relationship. As one operator who drove **\$1.2M** off LinkedIn puts it: *"the algorithm doesn't write you checks — people do. Every generic comment trains people to ignore you."* Casey Brown built a **40K** audience where **90% of clients come inbound**, and one comment thread turned into Sahil Bloom flying to Atlanta for a private event. This is a *system*, not random engagement.

The mindset: peer, not fan. Comment on **5–15 posts/day, not 50**. Only on posts from your **ideal clients, collaborators, or target-industry creators**. Before you comment, run the **coffee-shop test**: *"if I were sitting across from this person, what would I actually say?"* Add insight or ask a strategic question — never praise. Praise makes you a fan; insight makes you a peer, and clients hire peers. *"Comments are public auditions for your expertise."*

The Power List (the operating system). A simple Google Sheet, **4 columns: Category · Name · Profile link · Last engaged**. 20–30 targets. You rotate through it so you never ghost people or spam the same 3. Find targets via LinkedIn keyword + job-title search, by seeing who comments on industry leaders, and by mining who engages with competitors. Pair it with a **saved LinkedIn search feed** (build a filtered "posts from these people" search on desktop and **bookmark it**) so you catch their posts while fresh.

The 4 comment types that actually grow you:

1. **Value-add** — share a personal experience, tactical tip, or data that *expands* the post. (Example pulled 6,418 impressions off one comment.) You make the post *more* valuable for everyone reading.

1. **Challenge** — respectfully push back or ask a thought-provoking question. Thoughtful debate drives engagement; done right it makes the author reconsider without being confrontational.

1. **Supportive** — "I see what you're saying, here's my angle." Validate, then layer a deeper insight from your own experience. Builds relationship capital while staying visible.

1. **Witty / relatable** — when it fits. People remember how you made them feel.

Timing: comment in the **first 30–60 minutes**; being one of the **first 3–5 comments** ≈ guaranteed visibility (early engagement is weighted heaviest). The Power List is what lets you catch posts fresh.

Technical rules: comment from your **personal profile**; **optimize your profile first** (a half-filled profile wastes every click-through); **never "great post"**; make each comment substantial enough that *someone could reply to it and start a conversation*; and **never sell in comments** — that's for authority, the DMs come naturally.

AI as sparring partner, never author. AI that auto-posts comments = garbage that destroys your reputation. But a **Claude project trained on your tone, ICP, winning comments, and business insights** is smart: *you* formulate the insight ("we had this churn problem, here's what we learned"), then drop your draft in with "*refine this so it sounds like me — natural, sharp, short.*" The thinking stays yours; AI just polishes.

The 15-minute daily block (beats a 2-hour weekly binge):

- **10 min** — comment on 5–7 high-value posts from the Power List.
- **5 min** — reply to comments on your own recent posts (this is where relationships actually build).
- **+5 min end of day** — move promising comment threads into DMs.
- **Monday, 10 min** — update the Power List: add new targets, drop the inactive, re-star priorities.
- **Commit for 90 days**, 30–60 min/day. Consistency over volume.

Turn comments into a lead engine. Commenters are signaling intent. The pipeline: **capture commenters (Trigify)** → **enrich (Clay / other)** → **filter to ICP (e.g. CMO/VP at 50–500-person cos)** → **warm outreach (HeyReach)**. Because they already engaged with your content, acceptance and reply rates crush cold outbound. (*This is the same content→engager→Clay loop from Module 6 / Michel Lieben.*)

The engagement machine (Matt Gray). Beyond your own commenting, line up an **off-platform support circle** so **30+ people engage within the first 45 minutes** of a post (Matt gets ~25 within 30 min). LinkedIn is a *multiplayer* game — reposts especially are a top signal that pushes your post to new feeds, so a CTA that asks for a repost compounds reach.

Lesson 9 — Cadence & timing

- **3–5 posts/week is the sweet spot** (van der Blom + AuthoredUp agree; 4–5/wk ≈ +28% impressions/post vs weekly). Only ~4.5% of profiles hit this — do it and you're rare. Diminishing returns past 5.
- **Tuesday–Thursday** is the consensus core (matches our corpus: nearly every tracked expert's top days are Tue/Wed/Thu; weekends dead).
- **The 24-hour rule:** space posts ≥24h apart or they cannibalize.
- **Timing is contested** (mornings vs. 2026's shift to 3–8pm). Since the golden hour softened,

post when your audience is active and then feed the first 90 min — trust your own analytics over any universal clock.

Lesson 10 — Your profile is a conversion engine (and a reach setting)

Every post drives profile visits; the profile turns visitors into followers *and* tells 360Brew what you're about. A well-optimized profile converts ~40–60% of visitors to followers.

- **The Trifecta (Lara):** show the **same value proposition in banner + headline + Featured** so a

visitor hits it 3× → trust → follow.

- **Headline as a reach setting:** a value-prop headline ("I help [X] get [Y] via [Z]") gets ~+40%

profile views *and* feeds 360Brew's profile→post match (Lesson 3) — it literally defines what content the algorithm considers "on-brand" for you. Keep it keyword-true to your lane.

- **Featured section:** pin your best proof / lead magnet / top post — the conversion surface.
- **Creator mode / creator tools:** switches primary CTA from Connect→Follow, lifts the 30K connection

cap, unlocks Newsletter + Live + analytics. Essential for a growth (vs. networking) profile.

- **Newsletter:** subscribers get notified every issue — durable distribution outside the decaying feed.
- **Personalize every connection request** (Lara): reference their specific content + a relevant

overlap + a subtle ego-boost. Generic requests get ignored.

Lesson 10b — The profile is a landing page (and it never closes)

Reframe: **LinkedIn is a sales tool, not social media.** Your profile is a storefront open 24/7, and a stranger's brain lands on it hunting for reasons to *disqualify* you. A weaponized profile answers their **two objections before they're asked:** (1) "Can they help ME specifically?" (2) "Are they actually good?" (One simple profile of this kind reportedly drives \$400K/month with no ads or cold outreach — the profile does the selling.)

- **Headline (4 jobs): target · objection · positioning · offer.** Lead with the *transformation*, not

a job title (see the premium-positioning formula in Lesson 1).

- **About section — write it like a sales page, not a bio:** hook → *their* problem → their dream

outcome → your authority/proof → a CTA that sends them **off-platform** (newsletter, lead magnet). Write in second person about *them*, not third person about yourself.

- **Banner:** one clear outcome / value prop + **client or brand logos** for instant social proof.
- **One-liner that owns your word (Matt Gray):** e.g. "*systems I use to grow faster*" — memorable,

and it brands your keyword.

- **Featured section = a product shelf (Amazon/Apple model).** Don't just pin your best post. Build a

3-tier ladder the visitor can self-select into: - **Tier 1 — low friction, \$0–100:** newsletter, lead magnet, free template/checklist. - **Tier 2 — mid, \$500–2,000:** a consult, workshop, or small-scope done-for-you. - **Tier 3 — high, \$5,000–20,000+:** retainer, mastermind, coaching, full done-for-you. All tiers point into one ecosystem, so it's easy to upgrade someone from free → paid. **Clean, benefit-driven, clickable thumbnails — no paragraphs under the links** (extra clicks kill it; let the thumbnail sell, like a YouTube thumbnail).

- **Why fix the profile first (Lara's team):** *"you don't have a content problem, you have a*

positioning problem." Fix positioning and your content focus falls out of it automatically. Pick **one** section and fix it today — don't try to do all of it at once.

MODULE 5 — Monetization (attention → money)

Lesson 11 — The funnel: content is the top, not the whole

The hard truth every monetizer states: **virality ≠ leads ≠ sales**. The funnel is separate, intentional work.

- **Give away the secrets, sell the implementation** (Hormozi, echoed by Adam & the corpus). Only ~1%

implement; the other 99% pay you to. Content is "*the lubricant for the funnel*," not the funnel.

- **The comment-to-DM magnet (nick-abraham, proven)**. End posts with *"comment KEYWORD and I'll send*

it (must be connected)" — the "must be connected" grows your network on every post. This is our core engine; keep it on every post. Wrap links in a **free lead magnet**, never a raw sale.

- **Email is where the money lives, not followers (Lara)**. ~80% of her revenue came from her email

list, not her 300K+ audience. **Every lead magnet should capture an email.**

- **The offer ladder (Pierre, Welsh)**: a portfolio from ~\$19 → \$50K with multiple entry points;

the low-ticket product converts the audience, the high-ticket carries the revenue.

- **"Ask permission to sell" / EduSales (Lara)**: soft DM conversations *after* someone engages, never

cold pitching. Education embedded in the promotion so selling is frictionless.

Sequence: Post (attention) → save-worthy value (trust) → comment-to-DM lead magnet (email capture) → nurture → soft offer to warm engagers. Wire post-engagers into Clay for warm outbound (Michel's loop).

Lesson 12 — Founder-led growth & build-in-public (Taha's superpower)

Adam Robinson's radical-transparency model is the fastest founder-brand path:

- Post the **real numbers** — revenue, churn, wins *and losses*. He calls it "*B2B reality TV*." His

down-four-months-in-a-row posts were among his most popular. **Vulnerability cuts through** — "*if you're just willing to be human it will cut through the noise*."

- **Spend ~25% of writing time on the hook** ("if nobody clicks 'see more,' you wasted the post").

- **~1 in 10 posts sells; the other 9 build credibility**. Never sell directly — *"nobody wants to*

read that shit." Let the content create demand and the profile/site convert.

- **The free-tool flywheel**: an absurdly generous free product that demos itself → founder content

drives signups → transparent metrics feed more content. RB2B: \$0 → ~\$5M ARR in a year, zero paid ads.

- **The 3 Cs: Clear** (who you are) · **Consistent** (aligned message) · **Constant** (repeat your

story relentlessly).

The current wave = Taha's unfair advantage. "I built my GTM with Claude Code" is the hottest vein in the niche right now (kenny-damian's cheat-sheet: 1,033 likes; sacha built a Content Hub with Claude Code → **1,000 followers in 5 days**). Taha is *literally building an AI-powered agency in Claude Code right now*. He has the real thing to show — not a demo. **Build it in public = ride the highest-momentum wave with proof nobody else has.**

MODULE 6 — The systems (do it forever without burning out)

Lesson 13 — The repurposing factory (1 idea → 20 pieces)

Nobody sane writes fresh content daily. The pros run production systems:

- **Pierre's Repurposing Factory:** ideate **only from validated winners** ("extract and refine ideas

that already performed"), then run each through **~11 fixed repurposing routes** (post→newsletter; newsletter→15 posts, post→carousel...). "Inside one long-form piece you have 10 short-form ideas."* A solo operator outputs like a 4-person team and hits 30M views/yr.

- **Justin Welsh's Hub-and-Spoke:** the **newsletter is the hub**; chop each issue into **6–12 spokes**

across LinkedIn/X and **stagger them over 4–6 weeks**. Capture 10–15 ideas/day so you never stall.

- **Reverse-engineer winning formats (Michel, Lara, Welsh).** Find a format that's working, reverse the

hook/structure/CTA, replay it. Welsh's twist: **study creators' OLD posts** (the templates they used *before* they were famous), not their current ones.

Our free edge: these creators pay for Taplio's inspiration feed. **We already have the 6,642-post corpus + `FORMAT-LIBRARY.md` built from it** — the same capability, free. Mine it for winning formats.

Lesson 13b — The AI content engine: the 4 Levels of Claude

One creator went **1,200 → 14,000 followers in 90 days** by climbing four levels of AI leverage. This maps almost exactly onto what we've *already half-built* in `linkedin-hq` — the point is to actually use the higher levels.

- **Level 1 — chat prompting.** Ask Claude for a post; turn on web research to pull a ****hard statistic**

into the opening hook** (stat-led hooks over-perform). Fine for one-offs, but it "sounds like no one."

- **Level 2 — Claude Projects.** A saved system prompt + files (tone-of-voice guide, social proof,

personal stories). Predictable, on-brand output without re-prompting each time.

- **Level 3 — Skills that take action.** A skill that researches (web + Reddit for ICP pain), writes in

your voice, **and publishes to LinkedIn itself** via the Playwright browser CLI (logs in once, saves cookies). No copy-paste. **We already have the `/linkedin-post` skill and a comment system — this is the level to push them to.**

- **Level 3.5 — routines/schedule.** A scheduled run ("write + post daily at 8am, cycle a keyword

list") so you never miss a day. (Our roadmap's daily-post automation lives here — ToS risk noted.)

- **Level 4 — the knowledge vault.** The superpower: a full knowledge base (story, proof, testimonials,

performance data of what's already worked so it doesn't repeat) that powers the skill. It scrapes Reddit for your ICP's complaints, proposes 3 ideas, you pick one, it writes in your voice using your win-data, posts, and **auto-DMs everyone who comments** (via a lead tool). **This is exactly what `linkedin-hq` + the corpus + the Posts-tab performance data should become** — our vault already exists, it just isn't wired into the skill yet. (Auto-DM + auto-post carry ToS risk — keep a human in the loop.)

Lesson 14 — AI as co-pilot, never author

Universal consensus (Hassid, Matthews, Welsh, Lara): **AI for ideation and scaffolding; human for judgment, voice, and comments.** "AI is making high standards more essential, not less" (Hassid). Matthews: "ChatGPT writes my posts, but I make them better... AI sucks at comments" — his comments stay 100% human. Remember 360Brew reads the text and penalizes AI-obvious writing (–30% reach). **Your human voice is the only defensible moat left** (Lara). Our voice rules ([voice.md](#) , the banned-AI-words list) exist for exactly this.

Lesson 14b — The mindset laws (Jasmin Alić, live)

The craft above only works on top of the right mindset. Seven laws from LinkedIn's most-followed copy coach:

1. **The echo is the opportunity.** Everyone says LinkedIn is oversaturated with samey AI content —

that's exactly why it's the best time to post. The feed is full of posts that look, feel, and sound the same; a real human voice cuts straight through it.

1. **Share the person, not the information.** Everyone shares tips; almost nobody shares the *story

behind *the tips*. "How I crush my morning" *beats* "how to crush your morning"* — if people wanted generic tips they'd be on Google. On LinkedIn they want a real person. (This is Lara's how-to → how-I, from a second expert.)

1. **H2H, not B2B.** There are no businesses talking to businesses — it's always people talking to

people. Sound like a human even in the most "corporate" niche. The second you sound like a news outlet reporting information, you lose.

1. **Experiment relentlessly — everyone has their own algorithm.** Format, length, hooks, visuals,

power-endings: you won't know what lands with *your* audience until you test it. Don't copy what "works for someone else" without testing it on your own feed.

1. **Don't copy — stand out, not fit in.** The "jasmification" trap: chasing another creator's exact

style. Personal branding is about being unmistakably you. Like hip-hop, the copycats don't blow up — the ones with their own flavor do.

1. **Build the writing muscle.** Write every day. The more you write, the less you need hook templates

and frameworks as crutches — "*thinking is the skill we don't practice enough, and it comes through in writing.*" Templates are training wheels, not the destination.

1. **Share first, sell second — attraction, not sales.** "*The selling comes from the sharing.*" If all

you do is ask, ask, ask instead of give, give, give, you never build the trust that attracts. LinkedIn is a game of attraction. (Tools he lives in: **AuthorUp** for writing + analytics, **Kondo** for DMs.)

MODULE 7 — The synthesis: what's settled vs. what you must choose

Lesson 15 — The universal laws (all experts agree)

- 1. **The hook is the whole game, and it lives above "...see more."** Front-load everything.
- 2. **One idea, many assets** — repurpose validated winners; never recreate the wheel weekly.
- 3. **Specificity is the moat** — exact numbers, named results, real stories over generalities.
- 4. **Systematize ideation** so you never face a blank page (10–15 ideas/day; mine winners).
- 5. **Deliver value in-feed, not gated behind a link** (Natividad's "zero-click content").
- 6. **AI-assisted, never AI-authored** — and comments stay 100% human.
- 7. **Write like a person, to one person** — "be a person, not a logo."
- 8. **Warm before you sell** — content warms the room, comments warm the person, DM after warmth.
- 9. **Consistency compounds** — positioning is built over hundreds of connected posts, not one hit.

Lesson 15b — The bets you must choose (where experts genuinely disagree)

The mechanics are settled; the *strategy* is a set of lanes. Pick deliberately:

The choice	Camp A	Camp B	Our call for Taha
Growth lever	Comment-heavy (Alić: 20–30/day)	Post/distribution-heavy (Welsh)	Comment-heavy first — it's cheaper and Taha's reach is the bottleneck.
Hooks	Formula/templates (Hassid)	Anti-formula, human feel (Alić)	Use templates as training wheels, then trust feel.
Length	Short & punchy (Alić)	Long-form depth (Welsh, corpus)	<i>*Long</i> when substance earns it*** — save-worthy depth.
Voice	Polished authority (Welsh, Pierre)	Rough, human, real (Matthews, Adam)	Real + specific — matches Taha's operator identity + build-in-public.
Focus	One platform first (Welsh)	Omni-repurpose (Hassid, Matthews)	LinkedIn-first , repurpose later.
Content is...	Craft-first (Welsh, Alić)	Research-first (Bourgoin, Coleman)	Both — real client research → sharp posts.
Personal vs tactical	Story/vulnerability (Lara, Adam, Josh Braun)	Tactical frameworks (Pierre, Coleman)	~1 story post/week among tactical — stories are the biggest virals in our corpus.

MODULE 8 — Taha's pro strategy (everything, combined)

📌 **The DECIDED, canonical Taha strategy now lives in [STRATEGY.md](#)** (SMPV positioning, the stamped 3 pillars + 3×5 map, the contrarian bank) and this month's execution in [JULY-2026-STRATEGY.md](#). This module is the textbook-level summary; the two docs above are the source of truth.

The thesis: Taha's fastest path to cold-email-celebrity is to **fuse Michel's system (visual, comment-driven, build-in-public, wired to revenue) with Adam's radical transparency and Josh Braun's authentic story** — anchored to the one thing nobody can copy: **he's building a real AI-powered cold-email agency in Claude Code, live.**

The 5 pillars (operational)

1. **Ride the Claude-Code-GTM wave with real proof.** Turn the actual Second Brain / campaign-master build into announcement + case-study + teardown posts (the three highest-median formats in our corpus).
 1. **Lead with case-studies & build-announcements, ration hot takes.** Contrarian-take is the most-used and lowest-median format — everyone does it. Client results and builds win.
 1. **The visual is the point, every post.** 3–10× reach; our pipeline is built. Strong 1080×1350 visual or a <30s sped-up screen-recording of the system running (dwell-time gold, on-brand).
 1. **Run the engagement ritual religiously.** 30 min commenting before posting (hunt ICP in comment sections), post Tue/Wed/Thu 3×/wk → ramp to 4–5, reply to every comment in the first 30 min, comment-to-DM magnet on every post.
 1. **Close the loop to revenue.** Post-engagers → Clay via n8n → tier with LLMs → warm outbound. Turns every winner into booked meetings. (Needs Sophiya's sign-off on the automation.)

The first 30 days

- **Week 0:** turn on `sync-post-stats` (needs Apify key + sign-off) so every post gets a verdict; optimize Taha's profile trifecta (headline as reach-setting); pull 5 winning formats from `FORMAT-LIBRARY.md`.
- **Weeks 1–4:** 3 posts/week, Tue/Wed/Thu. Each week = **1 Claude-Code build case-study + 1 announcement/teardown + 1 authentic story.** Every post: strong visual + save-worthy substance + comment-CTA + the 30/30 ritual. Links in first comment only.
- **End of month:** review the Posts tab — now there's a real winner rate, and we can name Taha's own winning hooks/formats instead of extrapolating.

One-liner: position the lane (the AI-agency operator), win the first 90 minutes with comments, make the visual carry the reach, give away the secrets to build trust, and wire the engagers into Clay so the audience pays for itself.

Appendix — the source researchers (for deeper mining)

- **Lara Acosta** — SMPV, SLAY, "every line is a hook," email>followers, EduSales funnel; the 360Brew

paper decoded (profile-as-prompt, connected vs unconnected, beginner's advantage, 3 Ps, midwit curve, content-founder-fit, "your niche is a niche"). Kleo (her AI writing tool).

- **The "4 Levels of Claude" build** (1,200→14K in 90 days) — AI content-engine levels 1–4 (chat →

Projects → action-taking Skills w/ Playwright → routines → knowledge-vault + auto-DM). Maps to our own tooling.

- **Pierre Herubel** — Authority-First (70/20/10), 3×5 content map, anti-commodity test, Repurposing Factory.
- **Adam Robinson** — founder-led growth, radical transparency, free-tool flywheel, 3 Cs, 25%-on-the-hook.
- **Justin Welsh** — LinkedIn/Content OS, hub-and-spoke, Trailer/Meat/CTC, master one platform.
- **Jasmin Alić** — hook+rehook, comment 20–30/day, one-line hooks, specificity.
- **Ruben Hassid** — 55-char hook rule, 5 hook types, AI co-pilot.
- **Matt Gray** (Founder OS) — profitable-profile / engagement-machine / content-system, own-a-word,

4 post types, hook-in-3-lines, CTA science, 30+ engagers in 45 min, student-of-the-game.

- **Casey Brown** — the commenting-to-\$1.2M system (peer-not-fan, coffee-shop test, 5–15 not 50).
- **Jasmin Alić (live interview)** — the 7 mindset laws (echo=opportunity, share the person, H2H,

experiment, don't copy, writing muscle, share-first-sell-second), the video vanity trap.

- **Commenting-system + profile-teardown video transcripts** (2026-07-13/14) — the Power List, the

4 comment types, the 15-min daily block, comment→lead (Trigify→enrich→HeyReach), and the profile-as-landing-page / product-shelf featured section (Lara Acosta's team).

- **Algorithm science** — van der Blom (1.8M posts), AuthoredUp (3M format / 372K length), LinkedIn 360Brew papers.
- **Our corpus** — 6,642 tagged cold-email posts ([WINNER-RATE-PLAYBOOK.md](#) | \$3).